

Seawall height in Coral Gables

The elevation your city requires, the datum it is measured in, and the section of code that says so.

CORAL GABLES • MIAMI-DADE COUNTY

6.0 ft NGVD29 - a different datum again

Coral Gables states its requirement in NGVD29, the old datum, while most of its neighbours use NAVD88. The two are not interchangeable and the city publishes no conversion. It is also the only city we have read where a seawall permit can be routed to a public hearing before the City Commission, and where the Board of Architects reviews the design.

The detail

THE FIGURE	A minimum of 6 ft NGVD29, and the wall must structurally support 7.5 ft. Zoning Code Sec. 3-706.
TWO NUMBERS, TWO MEANINGS	The 6 ft is the elevation you build to. The 7.5 ft is structural capacity - what the wall must be able to carry. They are not the same requirement and should never be merged.
MIND THE DATUM	NGVD29, not NAVD88. The code states the datum explicitly and gives no conversion, and the offset between the two is local. Take it as written and get your datum from your survey.
NO MAXIMUM	Unlike Pompano Beach or Deerfield Beach, Coral Gables sets a floor and no ceiling.
ENGINEERED AND SPECIFIED	Plans must be designed by a Florida registered engineer, and the wall designed for loads imposed by saturated backfill. Reinforced, pre-stressed or gravity mass concrete - with block or native stone allowed only in water bodies west of LeJeune Road and north of Sunset Road.
THE PUBLIC HEARING MOST PEOPLE DO NOT EXPECT	A seawall or bulkhead is a Class 2 waterfront permit, and the code requires a public hearing before the City Commission before it is approved, with 15 days' published notice and courtesy notice to riparian owners within 1,000 feet. The exceptions that waive the hearing cover mooring piles, residential docks and dock repair - not seawalls. Sec. 109-42(c) and (f). Confirm current practice with Public Works, because this is the code as written.
A BIOLOGICAL SURVEY	Class 2 applications require a biological survey and ecological study. Sec. 109-42(b)(5)(e).
THE BOARD OF ARCHITECTS	Coral Gables reviews the look of the work. City Architect or Board of Architects approval is on the permit checklist, and the Building Official may not waive it.

THE BOND, CORRECTLY STATED	A performance bond set by the Public Works Director. The minimum is \$1,000 or 25% of the estimated cost, whichever is lesser; the maximum is 100% of the estimated cost. It stays in force at least six months after the approved completion date. Sec. 109-42(e)(3). A separate refundable damage deposit may also be required.
MAINTENANCE IS ENFORCEABLE	It is unlawful to let a retaining wall between your property and a canal deteriorate to the point it encroaches or falls into the canal. Sec. 86-119(b). After notice you have 20 days to remedy or request a hearing, after which the city may do the work and lien the property at 6% interest. Secs. 86-120 to 86-123. The scheduled civil penalty for failure to maintain waterfront improvements is \$400.
RECERTIFICATION	Any mooring structure ten years or older requires certification by a licensed engineer, and recertification every five years after. Sec. 109-44(b).
YOUR DOCK IS MEASURED OFF THE WALL	No dock more than 5 ft outward from the bank or the seawall, whichever is most restrictive. Sec. 3-702(A). Docks may not be covered or multi-level above grade.
KEEP THE CHANNEL CLEAR	75 ft of navigable width south of US-1, 45 ft north of it, and 30 ft in the Mahi Canal. Sec. 3-702(C).
TWO PERMITS AND A COUNTY STAMP	Public Works issues the Class 2 waterfront permit; Development Services runs the building permit; Miami-Dade DERM approval is required first and its stamp is required on revision re-submittals.

Where this comes from: City of Coral Gables Zoning Code Sec. 3-706 and Secs. 3-702, 3-705; Code of Ordinances Secs. 86-119 to 86-123, 109-40 to 109-44, 105-55, 1-7; City Fee Schedule and Development Services permit requirements, 2025

Verified: 2026-10. Rules change — check the date above against today.

Before you call a contractor

1 Know your datum

A height means nothing without the datum it is measured from. NAVD88 and MLW are different reference points and the same wall gives different numbers in each. Ask which one any quoted elevation refers to.

2 Get the existing elevation surveyed

You cannot tell whether a wall meets the requirement by looking at it. A surveyor shooting the top of the cap settles it in an hour.

3 Ask what triggers the requirement

Most cities only apply the minimum to new walls or to substantial repair. What counts as substantial is defined differently in each city, and it is usually a percentage of length or of cost.

4 Ask about building higher now

Several cities require a wall built below the final figure to be engineered so it can be raised later. Doing it once is cheaper than doing it twice.

